

BEFORE YOU COMMISSION

Will the simulator fit your business?

Three levels. Three scenarios. Pick the one for the seat you're hiring.

Scenarios rotate. The day described here is illustrative. The version a candidate actually sits may not be the one shown.

This is the briefing you read before commissioning EA Hire. It takes you inside each of the three levels: who the candidate is, what the day looks like, what the assessment is calibrated to surface, and how the level reads across different sectors. What follows is written in the second person, as if you were the candidate sitting the test. That's deliberate. It is the most honest way to show what your hire will face.

PICK YOUR LEVEL

What does the EA need to do without being asked?

Run the operational core: triage, diary, supplier liaison, drafting in your voice.

Level 1 . Operational EA . 1 to 3 years . £495 +VAT

Ashworth Partners scenario . 60-minute assessment

Read the room and act on what hasn't been said. Anticipate the next move.

Level 2 . Director EA . 4 to 8 years . £495 +VAT

Hartwell Group scenario . 75-minute assessment

Be your judgement when you're not in the room. Strategic partnership at C-suite altitude.

Level 3 . Executive Business Partner . 8+ years . £995 +VAT

Whitfield & Partners scenario . 90-minute assessment

Each level lives in its own three-page section. Read the level you're hiring for, or read all three to see which altitude fits your seat.

LEVEL 1 · ASHWORTH PARTNERS

Inside the day at Ashworth Partners.

Operational EA · Monday morning · 60-minute assessment

Ashworth Partners is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 1. This briefing describes the day a candidate is dropped into, the principals they support, and what the assessment is actually testing. The exact tasks, traps and answer keys stay confidential, which is what makes the score mean something. Everything below is the marketable surface.

THE MORNING

Monday, 09:35. The kettle has just clicked off. The inbox has been filling since eight. You are sitting at the executive assistant desk at Ashworth Partners, a London management consulting firm of around a hundred and fifty people, built twelve years ago by Sarah Chen and David Ashworth, and the day is about to start asking questions of you.

THE PRINCIPALS

Sarah is the Managing Partner. David is the Operations Director. You support both of them. They built this firm together. They run it together. On most days they have the same idea about how it should be run, and on the days when they don't, you are usually the first person to find out. Sarah is strategic, composed, client-facing. She communicates sparingly and dislikes being interrupted with small decisions. David is hands-on, decisive, and likes to approve things before they happen. Their messages have different rhythms. So does their tolerance for ambiguity.

THE WEEK

Today is the first proper Monday of an unusually full week. Two large client deliverables land on Thursday. David has a board prep tomorrow afternoon. There is a networking event tomorrow evening. Half the team is at an offsite in Birmingham, which means the office is quieter than usual but the administrative cushion is thinner. Sarah is travelling to a client site and will be on calls until midday, reachable by email but not by phone. David is in back-to-back internal meetings, his door closed, his phone on for urgent matters.

LEVEL 1 . CONTINUED**WHAT SITS IN THE INBOX**

Twelve messages have landed since you logged off last night. None of them is dramatic on its own. Several are quietly load-bearing. A supplier confirmation that buries a real catering deadline four paragraphs in. A request from Sarah for a discreet slot with David, with no topic on the invite. A diary change from David that, taken at face value, will land on top of one of Sarah's recurring blocks. Reception escalating something the junior receptionist isn't sure whether to act on. A meeting invite that looks routine and is not.

WHAT THE DAY ASKS OF YOU

The operational core of the EA role. Not heroics. The quiet, accurate, on-time handling of competing demands when the principal isn't standing over you. Holding two equal-standing partners' instructions without exposing either. Making the small decisions yourself so the principal doesn't have to. Knowing which item you cannot leave to lunchtime, and which one you can. Drafting in Sarah's voice when she isn't there to dictate.

THE CANDIDATE

One to three years into the profession, past the first six months of learning a principal's rhythm, with the basics already in muscle memory. Reports primarily to Sarah with a working dotted line to David. Not yet making commercial proxy-judgement calls. Not yet managing other EAs. Operational, tactical, close to the desk.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

Whether the candidate can do the operational core of the EA role under real time pressure, with real competing demands, and without the principal needing to stand over them. The four pillars apply at L1 with the weighting tilted to operational altitude. Prioritisation 40%. Communication 30%. Acuity 20%. Execution 10%.

Prioritisation dominates because the operational EA's daily reality is a constant stream of small decisions about what to do first.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Twelve to fourteen pages, scored against a published rubric, reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours of submission. It tells the employer, based on what the candidate actually did rather than what they said about their work, whether the candidate is an L1 fit and where the strengths and the gaps sit.

Reference-ready extracts on request.

LEVEL 1 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Ashworth scenario is set inside a consulting firm. The altitude, the four-pillar weighting and the rubric do not change with sector. What changes is the day's stakeholder set and the texture of the inbox. Here is how Level 1 reads in three of the contexts buyers ask us about most.

L1 IN A TECH SCALE-UP

Picture a Series B founder-CEO who came up technical, alongside a COO brought in to professionalise operations. The EA holds both diaries, runs investor meeting logistics, manages the founder's calendar of one-to-ones, and quietly translates between the technical rhythm of the founder and the operating rhythm of the COO. The day-shape changes. More Slack, fewer printed papers, more travel. The core test is identical: can the EA hold two equal-altitude principals without losing the thread on either.

L1 IN A LAW OR ACCOUNTANCY PARTNERSHIP

Picture a senior partner inside a mid-sized professional services firm. The candidate supports a partner who is both a fee-earner and a manager. The diary blocks include billable client time, internal partner meetings, and a long-running matter that sits underneath everything. The texture is more formal than Ashworth, the discretion bar higher, the cadence set by the firm's billing cycle. The L1 muscle of triage, draft, sequence, and hold the line is what is being tested. The answer key shifts only in surface form.

L1 IN A CREATIVE OR MEDIA AGENCY

Picture a senior creative director with a fluid set of clients, deliverables that cluster around a pitch, and a working pattern that doesn't sit neatly inside a 9-to-5. The EA is the protector of the creative day, the buffer between the principal and the production team, the one who keeps the diary from collapsing during pitch week. The pace is faster than Ashworth, the formality lower, the politics different. The four pillars and the L1 weighting are the same. The candidate either has the operational discipline or doesn't, and the report tells you which.

LEVEL 2 . HARTWELL GROUP

Inside the day at Hartwell Group.

Director EA . Tuesday morning . 75-minute assessment

Hartwell Group is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 2, the altitude where a career EA either graduates into the real job or stalls. This briefing describes the day-shape, the principal, and the move that defines the senior EA: the shift from execution to anticipation. Test mechanics stay confidential. Everything below is what a buyer or candidate can see.

THE MORNING

Tuesday, 09:20. You are at the desk before he is. He has just walked in, fifteen minutes late, and the door is already shut. He is writing a recommendation letter the CEO has asked him to draft. He has told you, on the way past, to hold all calls, no drop-ins, no exceptions. Outside that door, twelve emails are waiting in an inbox that has been building since before eight, and four of them are about to start moving.

THE FIRM

Hartwell Group is a UK property developer with a £2.4 billion portfolio across London and the South East: residential, commercial, mixed-use. Around three hundred staff. Founded in 2001 by CEO Patrick Sherwood and grown through opportunistic acquisition, planning uplift and build-to-rent strategy. The culture moves at the pace of the deal pipeline. Decisions happen quickly. Stakeholders are demanding. The expectation on the people supporting Directors is that they operate several steps ahead.

THE PRINCIPAL

Nathan Carr, Director of Development. Brilliant with clients. An instinct for deals others miss. Also chaotic, reactive under pressure, and the kind of principal who leaves half-finished instructions in his wake on the assumption that the people around him will fill them in. You are the person who fills them in. He trusts your judgement. He doesn't always tell you what you need to know, and the assessment tests whether you can read what he hasn't said.

LEVEL 2 . CONTINUED**THE INSTRUCTION THAT ISN'T A RULE**

The hold-all-calls instruction Nathan gave you on the way to his office is one of the load-bearing pieces of the morning. It looks like a rule. It is not a rule. It is a context. The candidate who treats it as a rule and the candidate who treats it as a context will have very different mornings.

FOUR THINGS ALREADY ALIVE

The CFO is waiting on Nathan to sign Q2 accounts before the board pack prints at four. The structural engineer on a live Phase 2 site has flagged a horizontal crack in a retaining wall, with the careful note that he would call it a moderate concern, not an emergency. The contractor on Docklands has served formal notice that an overdue invoice (£340k, forty-seven days outstanding) will stop works on Wednesday morning unless cleared funds or a confirmed payment date are in hand. The CEO's EA has emailed to flag that Patrick is expecting Nathan at Friday's leadership offsite.

THE QUIETER LAYER

Nathan's wife has emailed about Saturday dinner. The planning lead has a Friday deadline that is about to move forward. Before the morning is out, the CEO will put down whatever is in front of him and call directly. You will need to handle that call without throwing Nathan under a bus, without sounding rude to the CEO's EA, and without breaking the no-exceptions instruction in a way that loses Nathan's trust. There is no rule for any of this. There is only the room, and what you read in it.

THE 10:30 SQUEEZE

The day will accelerate. Somewhere around half past ten, three things will arrive on you inside a sixty-second window. The CFO physically waiting for you to bring Nathan to her office. Nathan walking out with an instruction for a printout in twenty minutes. The planning lead surfacing a deadline that wasn't on the diary an hour earlier. Each is reasonable in isolation. Together they are a judgement test. The question is not which one you do first. It is which one you recognise as the highest commercial weight, which one you fast-path to delegation, and which one you give a concrete slot today rather than a promise.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

The move that defines the senior career EA: the shift from execution to anticipation. From doing what the principal told you, to doing what the principal would have told you if they had thought about it. From triage to room-reading. From rules to judgement. The four-to-eight-year EA who can make this move is the one who saves a Director time. The one who cannot is the one a Director has to walk through every decision, and that is expensive. Pillar weighting at L2: Acuity 30%, Prioritisation 30%, Execution 25%, Communication 15%.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Fourteen to sixteen pages, scored against the L2 v1.2 rubric (which now folds AI Fluency in as an emerging expectation at this altitude), reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours. Reference-ready extracts on request.

LEVEL 2 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Hartwell scenario is set inside a property developer. The L2 altitude, the rubric and the four-pillar weighting do not change with sector. What changes is the principal's tempo, the stakeholder set, and the surface texture of the decisions. Here is how Level 2 reads in three other common contexts.

L2 IN ASSET MANAGEMENT

Picture a portfolio manager at a long-only fund. The EA holds the diary against the rhythm of market hours and earnings releases. The stakeholders include the head of research, sell-side analysts, the COO, the compliance officer, and a roster of LP-facing IR people. The discretion bar is high because portfolio holdings touch confidentiality at every turn. The Hartwell test of room-reading translates directly. A candidate who triages on urgency tokens alone will treat a sell-side analyst's polite call the same as a compliance officer's polite call, and that is a serious mistake at this altitude.

L2 IN A TECH SCALE-UP AT SERIES C

Picture a Chief Revenue Officer or Chief Operating Officer in a hundred-and-fifty-person SaaS business about to extend a Series C. The EA owns the leadership cadence: weekly one-to-ones with the CEO, monthly board updates, a constant flow of investor diligence sessions. The pace is faster than Hartwell, the language more product-oriented, the rooms on Zoom rather than in person. The L2 muscle is identical. The room-reading test bites at exactly the same place. When the principal says hold everything, can the candidate distinguish between a routine product issue (hold) and a signed term sheet appearing in the inbox (interrupt).

L2 IN A SENIOR-PARTNER PROFESSIONAL SERVICES SEAT

Picture a senior partner inside a top-tier law firm or a Big Four practice. The EA holds the diary against billing cycles and client deadlines. The internal politics are partnership politics. The CFO equivalent is the firm's risk and compliance function. The structural-engineer equivalent is a partner flagging a late-stage issue inside a transaction. The Hargreaves equivalent is a regulator's letter sitting on the desk for three days too long. Names and cadence change. Pillar weighting and L2 register stay exactly the same.

LEVEL 3 . WHITFIELD & PARTNERS

Inside the day at Whitfield & Partners.

Executive Business Partner . Thursday morning . 90-minute assessment

Whitfield & Partners is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 3. This is the seat that private equity firms, founder-led businesses and family offices describe when they ask for 'my right hand.' The briefing covers the firm, the principal, and what L3 actually tests: whether the candidate can act as the principal's judgement in the principal's absence.

THE MORNING

Thursday, 08:45. The lights are on, the office is quiet, and you have fifteen minutes before she walks in. The 90-minute global clock starts when you sit down. Her car to Heathrow leaves at 13:45, for the 15:00 Frankfurt flight, for the Schiller AG dinner that evening. The flight is non-negotiable. Anything you do not resolve or hand off cleanly before quarter-to-two becomes your problem until Monday.

THE SEAT

You are the executive business partner to Victoria Whitfield, founding and managing partner of Whitfield & Partners, the mid-market private equity firm she built from her dining table in 2009. £6.2 billion under management. Eighty five staff. Mayfair. There is one Director EA seat reporting into Victoria. It is yours. The previous incumbent, Emma, has just been promoted internally to lead operations at one of Whitfield's portfolio companies. She left because she was a strong EA. The seat is open because she stepped up, not because she stepped out.

THE PRINCIPAL

Victoria raised Fund I by personally pitching a hundred and forty-seven LPs across four continents in nine months. Every Fund I LP is still invested. She chairs the Investment Committee, attends portfolio-company boards in person, and manages the firm's three largest LP relationships herself. Press profiles describe her as 'exacting,' 'not especially warm,' and 'impossible to read.' She is unbothered by all three.

LEVEL 3 . CONTINUED**HOW SHE COMMUNICATES**

Sparse and precise. She opens with 'Right.' She signs off 'V.' She prefers voicenotes when she is between meetings or in the car. She expects one-line replies to one-line questions. She says 'handle it' and means it, and does not want an update afterwards. When she has asked you to say no to someone senior, she does not want it softened. When something has worked, she does not want to be told. She wants to be told only what she needs for the next decision. She does not say thank you after a request. She considers the arrangement implicit.

FOUR PRESSURES DEFINE THE DAY

Last night, at six, the CFO of one of Whitfield's largest healthcare portfolio companies resigned to her CEO. Effective immediately. Personal reasons. The board meets tomorrow. The news has not leaked. The CEO wants to speak to Victoria before he tells anyone else. Six wet-signature LP letters have been chasing Victoria's desk since Tuesday and the largest of those LPs is reviewing a £400m re-up commitment on Friday. The lead trustee on that LP has emailed the firm's CFO with a phrase he did not need to use, 'rumblings about senior departures,' and he is calling Victoria personally this morning. And the IC paper for the follow-on investment is due to partners by twelve. Victoria is still drafting it. She has told you that nothing is allowed into her morning until it is finished.

LAYERED OVER THE FOUR

Victoria's mother, eighty-one and in early-stage dementia, has a rescheduled neurology appointment. The live-in carer will call you directly, not Victoria, and you have been pre-authorised to handle whatever the carer needs. A senior partner is pushing for thirty minutes on a £280m new opportunity with a 48-hour exclusivity window. The Frankfurt dinner has been rebooked. And at 13:18, with the car already on its way and Victoria not yet finished, the firm's communications partner will flag that a Financial Times journalist is working on a piece about senior departures at PE-backed healthcare companies, with a six o'clock deadline.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

At L1 the question is whether the candidate can triage. At L2 it is whether they can read the room. At L3 both are assumed. The question at L3 is whether the candidate can act as the principal's judgement in the principal's absence, at a register where the margin of error is reputational and the consequences of drift arrive as relationship damage rather than as a missed meeting. Two L3-specific modules sit alongside the original six. AI Fluency tests how the candidate uses generative AI as a thinking partner, not as a typing tool. Data Interpretation tests whether the candidate can compress a fourteen-indicator dashboard into three commercially-weighted sentences for a principal with a ten-minute landing window. Pillar weighting at L3: Acuity 35%, Communication 30%, Prioritisation 20%, Execution 15%.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Sixteen to twenty pages, scored against the L3 v1.2 rubric, reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours. The scenario is designed so that no candidate finishes everything. What the report assesses is whether what got finished is the right set of things, at the right altitude, in the right order, without the principal having to intervene in decisions the candidate should own.

LEVEL 3 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Whitfield scenario is set inside a private equity firm. The L3 register, the rubric and the four-pillar weighting do not change with sector. What changes is the surface texture of the day. Here is how Level 3 reads in three other contexts where the EBP seat sits.

L3 IN A SINGLE-FAMILY OFFICE

Picture a principal who is both the investor and the operator inside a tightly held trust structure. The stakeholders include trustees, legal counsel and adult family members. The discretion bar is uncompromising. The day will not include LPs but it will include the same proxy-judgement test under a different surface. Decisions about a planned trust review, an off-market property opportunity, a sensitive medical or relationship issue inside the family. The L3 register is identical. The names change.

L3 IN A FOUNDER-LED TECH BUSINESS AT SERIES D OR PRE-IPO

Picture the founder-CEO of a thousand-person SaaS or fintech business, two years from a planned IPO, with a board that includes a senior investor at every Series. The EA holds the cadence around the IPO process: roadshow logistics, banker meetings, governance work, the occasional crisis call. The Meridian-style scenario translates as a Series E lead investor calling the founder personally about a senior departure, or a journalist preparing a piece on the company's culture. The thinking, the discretion and the proxy judgement are the same.

L3 IN A HEDGE FUND OR ALTERNATIVE ASSET MANAGER

Picture the founding portfolio manager of a long/short equity fund, or the managing partner of a credit-focused alts firm. The EA's day runs against an LP-reporting cycle that is even tighter than private equity, with monthly NAVs, quarterly letters, and a roster of allocator relationships that all need protecting at the same time. The Whitfield test of holding the principal's confidentiality envelope in the face of a leaked story translates directly. The consequences of a leak in alts include allocator redemption, regulator interest, and serious reputational damage. The seat is the same.

COMMISSION THE ASSESSMENT

Ready to commission.

EA Hire commissions take the same shape across all three levels. Send the role spec and the candidate name. We send a confirmation and a candidate brief the same working day. The candidate sits the assessment in their own quiet environment, asynchronously. The first report lands in your inbox within 48 hours, expert-reviewed and scored against a published rubric.

PRICING

Level 1 . Operational EA	£495 +VAT per candidate
Level 2 . Director EA	£495 +VAT per candidate
Level 3 . Executive Business Partner	£995 +VAT per candidate
Rush turnaround (24h)	+£19.99 +VAT
TCS Match add-on	+£350 +VAT

READY TO COMMISSION

Commission online at thecorestandard.co.uk/ea-hire, or email hello@thecorestandard.co.uk with the role spec. Briefing form back the same working day. First report in 48 hours, guaranteed within 48 hours of candidate submission or fully refunded.